LAUNCH PAD · A GUIDE'S LESSON PLAN BOOK

The Helm Year

What do I do when there is no easy answer?

A guide's book for Year Three of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

VIBRANT LIFE

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

Part 3 - The sessions

1. The Mantle (four weeks, Aug 13 - Sep 6)
2. No Easy Answers (five weeks, Sep 17 - Oct 18) - one of the three heaviest
3. The Ripple (three weeks, Oct 29 - Nov 15, ends into Thanksgiving)
4. The Stage (three weeks, Nov 26 - Dec 13, ends into the winter break) - one of the three heaviest
5. The Arena of Voices (six weeks, Dec 31 - Feb 7)
6. The Bridge (six weeks, Feb 18 - Mar 28)
7. The Council (four weeks, Apr 8 - May 2) - the harvest, one of the three heaviest

Part 4 - Closing the year and the Launch

A short opening note

This is a book for the guide who runs the third and final year of the Launch Pad - the year called The Helm. It is also a book any learner is welcome to read cover to cover. There is nothing in here to hide from you.

That is a promise with a shape. Everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read; nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in "quotes" are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is written for the guide to understand and hold - the reasons behind the moves, the care under the plan. When a note is written for the guide, it is still written to be read by a learner. There is no second, secret version.

One author's note on language: this book was written by Erin Stanley, who opened the studio and guided its first year. "The guide" means whoever is leading the studio, and this book says "they" throughout, because that will not always be the same person. Where the book says the guide is raising a small child, that is the shape of the year it was written for, named so the shape is owned; a later guide names their own shape in the same place. "You" sometimes means the guide and sometimes means the learner - the context always makes it clear which.

One more thing to say plainly at the start: this is the heaviest year in the three-year story, so the care around it is built up thickest. The material is real. It touches hard calls, mortality, shame, leadership, and, at the end, leaving. Which version a tribe runs, the lighter or the full, is decided by the guide before the year, and you will be told which. Inside it, every heavy day is yours to step out of, and the lighter path is always honorable, never a lesser version of the year. Held well, this year can change a person. Some will feel that, some won't yet, and both are true.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

The Helm is the year of **the hard call, and loving the life around it.**

The whole question of the year is this: *What do I do when there is no easy answer?* Not "how do I win." Instead: how do I face something that cannot be cleanly won? How do I make the call from my own principles, name what it costs, and not lose myself doing it? And how do I still love my actual life while I do?

The three years each carry their own question:

- **Origin - Who am I?** (Know your story.)
- **The Forge - What is worth solving?** (Find your work.)
- **The Helm - What do I do when there is no easy answer?** (Make the hard call, and love the life around it.)

The three years turn as a cycle rather than a ladder. Whichever year is running when you arrive is the one you start in, and you are not behind. You do not have to have done Origin or the Forge to start here. Your Log starts today, your Vineyard is named this week, and your Evidence File is built from any real proof you have. In the shared work you are a full Helm learner from the first morning. If you are not launching this year, the Council is yours all the same; the Launch is a rite for whoever is leaving, and the year's close is yours.

The journey

The Launch Pad is three years, three expeditions. The first year, Origin, is about **dreaming it**: who am I? The second year, The Forge, is about **building it**: what is worth solving? The Helm is the resolution. It is where you learn to make a real decision from your own principles, in the open, in front of your people, and still go home and love your life.

The arc runs self, then world, then the hard call. By now you know your story and you have found work worth doing. This year you learn four things. To reason when you truly cannot know the answer. To live with a hard decision. To lead the people beside you. To be mentored by adults who are further down the road. And one more: to choose life *because* you have looked at hard things, not by looking away from them.

The daily practice of this year is the **no-win scenario.** It is the practice of standing inside a situation that has no clean answer, long enough to reason from principle instead of reaching for the exit. It is the same muscle you have been building the whole time. In Origin you made small real choices in games. In The Forge you stood inside questions too big to close. This year you make the hard call inside a situation that cannot be won. Same muscle, one more turn.

Named plainly, the seven sessions are:

1. **The Mantle** - meet the feeling of not-belonging-yet, and take up what you will carry.
2. **No Easy Answers** - reason through real dilemmas from principle, out loud.
3. **The Ripple** - look downstream of a choice, and stay humble about what you can't see.
4. **The Stage** - feel a hard call from inside the lives it touches, through theatre.
5. **The Arena of Voices** - learn from adults further down the road, and how to be mentored well.
6. **The Bridge** - lead the people beside you, and be led.
7. **The Council** - make a hard call in the open, before your people.

The words this book uses

This studio has its own small vocabulary. None of it is a secret, so here it all is, before you meet any of it.

- **A quest.** One piece of work with a beginning and an end: a prompt, a case, a scene, a share. It is the unit you can say no to.
- **A session.** One of the year's seven stretches, each with its own question. Three to six weeks long, with a break after it.
- **Core.** Short for your core academics: the high-school credit work you have claimed, at your own pace, on your own days.
- **The settle.** The three slow breaths that open every guide day.
- **The way down.** Standing up and shaking it out after hard work, so your body can put the stress down.

- **The exit ramp.** The named place you can step out to, without asking, and come back from with nothing said.
- **The close-return.** The words the room says out loud after a heavy day, so your body hears that the heavy part is over. Always the same words; they are on the settle page.
- **The closing minute.** The three private questions at the end of an opening. Never written for the studio, never read by anyone.
- **The Captain's Log.** Your own record of your own life. Yours.
- **The Vineyard.** The thing you love that nobody ever makes useful.
- **The Work of the Day.** The one piece of the session's work the whole tribe does together that morning, named out loud at the start so you know what the day is for.
- **Your tribe.** The people in this studio with you.
- **Your crew.** Two things share this word. On a heavy day it is the one other learner who notices you and whom you notice; never a watch set on you. In the leadership work it is the people you lead and are led by.
- **The walk-in.** Two things share this word. The walk-in is the soft first stretch of a guide day, when the door is open and nothing is required. It is also what we call the quiet one-to-one conversations that happen inside that window, where the guide comes to one or two people rather than calling anyone over. "I'll catch you in the walk-in" means a conversation, not a meeting, and nothing in it is written down.
- **Fallow.** Deliberately empty. Fallow is a farming word: a fallow field is one you leave unplanted on purpose, because that is what makes it rich again. Fridays are fallow. Never earned, never filled.
- **A harvest.** The last stretch of a session, where you gather what the weeks grew and name what you got. It is yours to gather, and an empty harvest is a real harvest.
- **Witnessed.** Someone was there and saw it. Not watched, not assessed. Being witnessed is a gift and never a demand.
- **A re-thread.** Picking the year back up after a break. The first guide day back starts with it: where were you, where are you now, what came back changed. You are never restarting cold.
- **The pace question.** The guide asking whether the plan still matches the speed your real life is running at.

- **The re-ask.** The guide asking, out loud, *is this still yours?* It is not a mood check and it is not rhetorical. "No" and "I don't know" are both real answers, and it gets asked at points in the year where there is still time to act on the answer.
- **The no-win scenario.** The year's daily practice: standing inside a situation that cannot be cleanly won, long enough to choose from principle instead of grabbing the exit. The name is borrowed from an old Star Trek story about a training test built so nobody can pass it. In the story the hero cheats the test; that part is the bait, not the lesson.
- **The hard call.** A decision where every path costs something real. Making one well: from principle, cost named, without losing yourself.
- **The Mantle.** A real object you take up in the first session and carry all year. It stands for "I am someone who can hold a hard call." At the end you decide to keep it or leave it; both are true.
- **The Evidence File.** Real proof you have already done hard things, pulled from your own record. It lines the Mantle, so the proof is in the pocket when not-belonging shows up.
- **The Reasoning Standard.** Five questions a hard call must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer."
- **A real dilemma, and a rationalized wrong.** A real dilemma has two real goods pulling against each other. A rationalized wrong has one, dressed as two.
- **Steelman.** Saying the side you disagree with so well its holder would say "yes, that's it." You may not argue your own side until you have.
- **Forum Theatre.** A hard-call scene is acted out; anyone can stop it, step in, and try a different choice. Deliberation you can see.
- **De-roling.** Stepping out of a part: say your name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out, feel what is under you. It closes a role. It never closes real grief; the closing minute does that.
- **The second adult.** On the deep days of the three heaviest sessions, a second adult whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave. No second adult that week, the heavy block waits.
- **The Council.** The year's harvest: a hard call made in the open, in front of your people, by reasoning together. Not a debate. A debate has a winner.
- **The Third Chair.** An empty chair between two hardened sides, holding four questions: what is each side protecting, is the "or" real or inherited, what would honor both, and if nothing can, which do we choose and what do we grieve.

- **The steward of the absent.** The one Council seat whose only job is "who is affected by this who is not in the room?"
- **The Launch.** The rite at the end of three years for a learner leaving: the ending named, a threshold crossed in front of your people, the door left unlocked from your side. Nobody is ever pulled back through it.
- **The Star Chart.** The map of where you have been, handed to you at the Launch, at the moment you must steer by it alone.

What you make and carry

Three things belong to you this year, and one of them you carry out the door for the rest of your life.

The Captain's Log. This has been yours since your first day here, whichever year that was. It is your private voice, your record of what you met and what you carried. A guide never reads it to grade you or check on you; it was never surveillance and it never will be. It is yours every day, not only at the end: it goes where you say, home or a place here only you open, and no copy is ever made, because the moment there is a copy somebody else is holding your life. At every year's close the handoff is said aloud, and if you leave, you carry it out the door.

The Mantle. This year you take up a Mantle: a role, a way of standing, an "I am someone who can hold a hard call." You take it up in the first session, you wear it into the leadership work and the Council, and at the very end you decide, on your own, whether to keep it or leave it. Both choices are true. The choosing is the point.

The Vineyard. This is the thing you love that has nothing to do with the curriculum: the instrument, the trail, the craft, the friendship, the game, the album on the floor. It was named on your first day here as the quiet twin of the Captain's Log, and by now it has roots. It is never made useful, because the moment it is useful it stops being a Vineyard. No one grades it, no one turns it into a lesson, no one asks you to reflect on it. At the Launch, the one small thing you leave for the room *can* be your Vineyard-thing, if you choose; it can also be anything else, and nobody will ask. Loving your life is not a footnote to making hard calls. It is what the hard calls are *for*.

When, and this is the one part that is required. Making time for something you love is a requirement of this programme. Not a particular thing, not a certain number of hours, and not anything you hand in. The requirement is that the time is in your week and that something you love is in the time. Friday is already yours and is the obvious home; the tail of a Tuesday

is another. Nobody ever checks what you did with the time. The only question anyone will ever ask is *is the time there.* The requirement binds us to keep making room for it. It does not bind you to fill the room.

The promises (the six refusals)

Underneath everything, there is a floor of promises. Nothing in the Launch Pad is allowed to break these. In plain words:

1. **No grades or scores anyone but you can see.** Your progress is yours. High-school credit is the one honest exception, and it is explained at the end of this Part.
2. **No ranking and no leaderboards.** You are never stacked against the person next to you. A parent linked to your account can see which of your own goals you have finished, and that is the whole of what anyone else sees. If that ever stops being exactly true, you will be told before it changes, not after.
3. **No one deposits the answers into you.** You make meaning here; the guide holds questions and walks with you, and does not hand you a finished answer.
4. **No imposed deadlines.** You set your own pace. "I didn't get to it" is honored, not punished.
5. **Your worth is not your output.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts as much as one you finished. Doing more does not make you worth more.
6. **No surveillance.** The data of your life belongs to you, not to the school. This promise is about a short list of what gets written down about you, and the list is at the end of this Part so you can check it.

And one more, which sits on top of the six:

You may refuse the structure itself. If you decline a whole quest, you are fully honored. You are not quietly marked down as a failure or an opt-out. Your no is real.

Where your no reaches, and where it stops

Here is the edge of that last promise, said now rather than discovered later.

Your no covers your own work. A quest, a case, a role, a scene, a share, a whole session, this entire structure. It lands the moment you say it, it costs you nothing, and nobody can overrule it.

It does not cover how you treat the people in the room with you. That is not a deadline and it is not output. It is the floor that makes everything else here safe for the other people in the room, and it is the one place in this programme where something can actually be taken from you. The studio's agreements run that floor, and they have their own ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. You will meet it in your first week, and you will help write the agreements it rests on. The count clears at the start of every year, so nothing from last year walks in with you.

So, in one line: **the agreements are about how we treat each other. The promises are about whether you do the work.**

Declining a quest is never a Pause. A Pause is never a judgement on your work, your pace, or whether you are keeping up. If anyone ever runs those two together, they have got it wrong, and you can say so out loud and point at this page.

And if you do not sign. You are in the room anyway, and that was never the price of being here. The agreements still run for you, and here is the honest reason rather than a convenient one: they are not holding you to your word, because you did not give it. They are holding the room safe for the people in it with you. You can tell us the agreements are not yours. You cannot be outside the floor, because **the floor is not about you.**

How we work: the week

The studio day runs through the morning, 9:00 to 1:00. Across the week, two mornings are guide days and two are your own.

- **Guide days (Tuesday and Thursday).** The guide runs the studio with you. The order of the morning is below, and it is the same every time. What differs this year is the middle: Tuesday's work is lighter, and Thursday holds the week's one deep block. That is on purpose. The guide is running the studio solo while raising a small child, and chose the shape that holds rather than the shape that looks fuller, and says so out loud.
- **Your-own days (Monday and Wednesday).** You run your own morning: your reading, your core academics, your personal project, and the session's writing. Nobody is steering but you. The guide is in the building, at Vibrant Life Tots with the younger children from 9:15 to 11:30, and then the guide comes to you around noon for a real check-in. Same site, different room. If you need them before noon, you go and get them. You are genuinely running your own hours and you are never actually alone in the building. Both of those are true at once.

- **The fallow day (Friday).** Protected. Never earned, never filled, never converted back into work. It is for rest, play, friendship, and making things for no reason. This is not a reward for finishing. It is practice for a whole life. And it is binding: it does not get eaten to cover a busy week. It is for you and for the guide both.

A guided morning, start to finish

Guide days run 9:00 to 1:00. The order is the same on both days, so you never walk in wondering what today is. What changes between Tuesday and Thursday is the middle block.

Time	What happens
9:00 - 9:25	**The walk-in.** Door open, nothing required. Put your things down, make tea, talk or don't. The guide is here and will come find one or two people for a quiet one-to-one.
9:25 - 9:35	**The settle, then the circle.** Three breaths, the same words every time. Then one round of "how are you, really?" You may pass.
9:35 - 10:50	**The Work of the Day.** Tuesday: the day's no-win question, then the lighter work - group challenges, theatre as play, leadership practice, planning an outing. Thursday: the week's one deep block. On the three heaviest Thursdays there is a second adult in the room, and you will know which weeks those are before they come. This is the part that changes week to week. The rest of this table does not.
10:50 - 11:00	**The way down.** Stand, shake it out, step outside, water. Then we eat.
11:00 - 11:40	**The Table.** We eat together. You bring your own lunch. On a heavy Thursday this is the come-down, and nothing is asked of you at it.
11:40 - 12:40	**Hands and each other.** Making, building, rehearsing, an errand, a project with somebody else. Different from the morning's work on purpose: the body works and the

Time	What happens
	talking gets easy. On Tuesdays this is a fine home for your Vineyard if you want it there; nobody asks.
12:40 - 1:00	**The close.** One light thing, then your closing minute, then you go.

The times are honest rather than strict. Most days drift ten minutes. The order never drifts.

The Table

Every guide day has a shared meal in the middle of it. Here is exactly how it goes.

You bring your own lunch. On ordinary days the studio does not provide the food.

It is still a shared table rather than a lunch break. We stop, sit down together, and the guide sits and eats with you. The forty minutes is for being a group of people who eat together, not for getting through food on the way to the next thing.

You sit wherever you want. Seats are not assigned, and nobody's seat is kept from last week.

You do not have to eat. Presence is the whole requirement here, never consumption. If you are fasting, or observing, or not hungry, or food is a hard thing for you right now, you sit with us and that is full participation. Nobody watches anybody's plate, and you never owe anyone an explanation for what is or is not on yours.

If you arrive late, come in and sit down. Nothing restarts, and nobody asks where you were in front of the room.

On the one day a year when there *is* shared food, the feast after the Council, tell the guide what you cannot eat, once, whenever you know it. Planning around it is the guide's job rather than yours to work around. That day the studio provides the base of the meal, and bringing a dish is never required. If you want what the studio brings to stand as yours, say so to the guide once, privately, and it will. Nobody at the table will know the difference, and nobody will ask.

Sometimes a guest speaker is with us across the Table. They eat with us by the same rule, and the guide tells them the shape before they come. You never owe a guest a performance of gratitude for sitting with us. Being at the table is the thanks.

The circle: "how are you, really?"

Right after the settle, every guide day, we go around once. The question is "how are you, really?" and it means the real answer rather than the automatic one.

Here is how it goes. The guide asks, and answers first, honestly and briefly. Then it goes around in order, so nobody is picked on and nobody has to volunteer. One or two sentences each is plenty. "Tired." "Good, actually." "I don't want to say today." Those are complete answers.

You can always pass. Say "pass" and it moves on, with no follow-up and no note taken. Passing is not a smaller answer. A person who passes has been round the circle the same as everyone else.

Nobody fixes what you say here unless you ask. Advice that arrives unasked is not help, so the circle starts from being heard.

But you can ask, and you can ask the room. "Does anyone know what to do about this?" is a completely normal thing to say in a circle, and so is "I just wanted to say it, I don't want to talk about it." Both are answers to the same question, and the question is yours: **do you want this held, or do you want it worked?** Say which and the room will follow you. Six people who know you is not a smaller resource than one guide, and some things a seventeen-year-old knows better than any adult in the building.

If you would rather not ask in front of everyone, that is equally fine. Say so, or say nothing and catch the guide afterwards.

It takes a few minutes. It is not a check-up, and nothing said in it is written down.

Who else is in the room

There are a handful of you and one of me, and my child is now small enough to be in Vibrant Life Tots on Monday and Wednesday mornings, which is where I am too on your own days. On Tuesdays the child is in the studio with us; a three-year-old talks, and may talk to you. On Thursdays the child is out of the room for the deep block, with a named person arranged before the year opens. If that cover falls through on a given Thursday, the deep block waits for the next one and the morning turns into hands and each other. That is the design working, not a lost day, and you will be told which it is rather than left to guess.

On the three heaviest Thursdays there is also a second adult in the room. They are not here for the child. They are here for the room, so that if one of you needs to step out, somebody can go

with you and I never have to choose between the room and you. If they cannot be there one week, the lighter version of the day runs and the deep version waits. You will know who they are before the first heavy week. They are another trained adult, never one of you.

And the same two plain things as every year. You are never asked to mind my child, not for a minute, not as a favour. And if you ever need all of me, a hard day or a conversation that cannot be interrupted, say so, and I will make the handoff happen rather than make you wait.

Arriving late, stepping out, coming back

Arriving late. Walk in. There is no procedure and nothing restarts. If the circle is going, join where it has got to, or pass. If the settle is going, sit down and pick it up on the next breath. Nobody will ask you in front of the room where you were. If something made you late and you want the guide to know, catch them at the Table.

Coming back after stepping out. The soft parts of the day are named so you know where the easiest way back in is: the walk-in, the Table, and the hands block after it. You can come back at any moment, including the middle of a hard one. The soft seams are just the ones where nothing has to be said at all. Nobody says anything to you when you come back. Not even "glad you're back." You pick up a plate or pick up a tool and you are in.

On a heavy Thursday, stepping out works the same way, and the exit is named again that morning for that room. If the second adult comes out with you, you do not have to talk to them. They are there so that nobody is alone with a hard thing. During the Council there is also the pass signal, which hands the floor back at no cost and with no explanation.

The Log, captured however you hold it

You keep the Captain's Log in whatever form is true to you. Written in a notebook. Spoken aloud and recorded. Drawn. Dictated. Typed. Told to a scribe who writes it down for you. No form is the lesser Log. The point is that you are keeping your own record, not that it looks a certain way.

Where it lives. Your Log can go home with you, or stay here somewhere only you open, or both, and you can change your mind any time. If you want it to stay here, say so and nobody asks why. It is not kept in the Compass or on any school computer, and no copy is made.

When you write in it. There is no Log time and nobody will ever call one. The walk-in, right after your closing minute, your own mornings, and Friday if you want it are all open rather than expected. A record you have to feed every day stops being a record and becomes a chore,

and **there are supposed to be days you skip.** A Log with gaps in it is not a failed Log; it is what an honest one looks like.

One rule about this, and it is for the guide as much as you: **nobody writes on a bell.** We will never all sit down and write at the same time, because the moment that happens, everyone can see who is writing and who is not, and the only thing that makes this yours is that nobody is watching.

How "no" works here

You may decline anything. **Your no takes effect the moment you say it, and it is not conditional on explaining yourself.** This is called **decline-with-reasoning**, and here is the honest shape of it.

You can say no to any quest, any case, any role, any share, and the no lands straight away. Nothing is held up while you find words.

The reasoning is still owed. Two things about that, and they matter equally. **It is owed to your tribe, not to the guide.** You are in a room with other people whose work and plans move around yours, so they get to know where you stand. It is not a toll you pay an adult for permission. And **it is not owed in the moment.** "I don't know yet, and I'll come back to you" is a real answer. Take a day. Take the week. Work it out in your Log first and come back when you have it. A reason you had to produce on the spot is not thinking, it is pressure.

The guide may ask you an honest, curious question about it, the way a friend might. But the guide **has a voice, never a veto.** The guide cannot overrule your reason, and cannot require you to have one ready. The question is a mirror, not a test you can fail.

There is one place where even the curious question is set aside: anything to do with official papers and government forms. There, an honest reason for declining might reveal something private about your legal situation that a guide has no business knowing. So on that one surface, your no needs no reason at all.

Meeting a hard thing with the ordinary supports. Twice this year, in the two lighter sessions, you may choose to meet a hard thing with the ordinary supports instead of the full net: the guide present, the exit there, the visible crew turned down. It is offered, you choose it by name, and it is never sprung on you. The floor's availability never goes down; only how loudly it is announced. It is never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough, because the point is an ordinary-sized hard thing met with ordinary support, not a wound made on purpose.

The settle

Every guide day opens with a short, body-first way in, and there is a matching way down when something gets heavy. This is fixed, and it is yours to keep for life.

- **The way in (the settle).** Three slow breaths with the out-breath longer than the in-breath (roughly four counts in, six counts out), feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. The out-breath is what tells your body it is safe to settle. No app, no playlist, no special frequency. Just a human voice, used the same way on purpose. It is the same three moves every day, all three years, because the sameness is what lets it become yours. When you are forty and something cracks you open, this is a way to come home to yourself.
- **The way down.** After hard work stirs the body up, you stand, shake it out, take a short walk, move the activation *through* the body before sitting back down. If standing or walking is not yours, any movement that is - shaking out your hands, rolling your shoulders, rocking - does the same work. You cannot metabolize a stress spike sitting still. On heavy days there is a short one in the middle of the work too: thirty seconds, feet on the floor or hands on the chair, look around the room, one breath.
- **The way out (the exit ramp).** There is a named place you can step out to, set up in the first week. You do not have to ask. And there is a designed way back in during a soft part of the day, with no scene, no acknowledgment demanded. Stepping out and coming back costs you nothing. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.
- **The way back (the close-return).** After a day that went somewhere heavy, the room says out loud that the heavy part is over, so your body hears it and not just your head. These words do not change either:

  > SAY
  >
  > "That was then. This is now. Look around and name one thing you can see. You're in this room, and the hard part is behind you."

  It sounds almost too simple to do anything. It works because a body that has been inside a hard thing for an hour does not automatically notice that the hour ended, and being told, in words, is how it notices. Solo version, for the rest of your life: *that was then, this is now, and I'm here.*

One more close belongs to this year, because this year you wear other lives on a stage. **De-roling** closes a role: say or sign your own name, three true things about your real life, prop down, shake out whatever part of you moves, feel what is under you. It says "that wasn't me." The close-return and the closing minute close a real feeling the role opened: "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here." They are kept strictly separate, because real grief is never something a learner is asked to put down like a costume.

The closing minute

At the close of an opening - a dilemma reasoned, a life tried on, a hard conversation - you take a quiet minute and cross back through three fixed questions. They are always the same, in the same order:

1. **What did I meet?**
2. **What do I carry back?**
3. **What's different in me now - even a little?**

That is the whole practice. It is spoken or held in your head, never written down for the studio, never read by anyone. It is yours. It runs at the close of every guide day, light days included, because a practice used only on heavy days never becomes the one you reach for at forty.

Reach for the real answer. Taking the first thing that comes to mind and moving on makes this worth almost nothing. Staying in the question for a whole minute and letting something come up makes it worth a great deal, and **something almost always comes up, if you stay open long enough to hear it.** That takes a kind of nerve. It is the same nerve the rest of this year asks for.

"I don't know yet" is a real answer, not because the question has no answer, but because sometimes the true one has not surfaced, and naming that beats manufacturing something to have said. "Nothing's different, and I'm steadier for having looked" is also true and complete, because steadier is a change.

But you will know the difference between *I don't know yet* and *I didn't look.* Nobody else ever will. Nobody reads this, nobody asks about it, and no one can tell from the outside whether you reached or shrugged. **This is the one practice here that runs entirely on your own honour**, and what you do with a quiet minute when nobody is checking is worth knowing about yourself. The whole point is that you can run it on yourself for the rest of your life, at a kitchen table at 2 a.m., with no guide in the room.

The one adult outside the room

There is one adult, outside the studio, you can always talk to. You will know who they are and how to reach them in the first week, before you ever need them.

One honest line about breaks, said now. When the studio is on a break - the short ones between sessions, Thanksgiving, the two weeks at winter - the guide is not reachable. A break is rest and reset for them too, and the book protects that the same way it protects your Friday. The one adult outside the room is reachable across every break, the same as always. And if you are ever in danger, or someone else is, **988** is free, open all day and all night, and you can call or text it from anywhere. Nobody here will ever be upset that you used it.

And this is the honest shape of privacy, said on the first day rather than saved for the moment it matters. Almost everything stays here. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads. Your closing minute is never written down by anyone.

Here is what doesn't. If the guide believes you are in danger, that someone is hurting or neglecting you, or that something is going on that is bigger than a studio morning can hold, they will bring in real help. That includes talk of suicide or self-harm, abuse or neglect, something going wrong with eating, a crisis with drugs or alcohol, a panic or a flashback they cannot reach you through, a threat to someone else, or something that keeps going and is getting in the way of your life.

Those are two different things and they have different consequences, so both get named. **Abuse or neglect is a report**, and in Idaho the guide is required by law to make it. **Everything else on that list is a hand-off**, which means they stop the session work and help you get to someone trained, you will be told who, and you get a say in which one and when.

In most of those cases they will also call your parent or guardian, and they will tell you they are making the call. The one exception is if your parent or guardian is the person hurting you. Then the call goes to the state rather than to them.

That is the whole list. It is not one secret trapdoor, and the guide will never go looking for a reason to use it. **What they know is only what you chose to tell them.** None of this is breaking trust. It is what care actually looks like.

What gets written down about you

Short answer: very little, and you can read all of it.

- **Your Captain's Log and your Vineyard.** Yours. Nobody reads them. No copy is kept.

- **Your closing minute.** Never written down at all, by anyone.
- **Your witnessed work** - your reasoned position on a hard case, a monologue if you perform it, the Council board, your Evidence File, your next-step plan. The guide sees what you bring into the room, and so do the people you choose to show. That is what bringing it means.
- **The guide's own notes.** A short practical record: attendance, your pace and your credit plan, and a factual note if there is ever a safety event, meaning what happened, what they did, and who they called. A safety note never contains what you wrote or said about your own life.
- **The cards from the first session.** If you write one, it is read once in the guide's voice with no name, and then it is gone. Nobody keeps them or matches a hand to a name.
- **A recent loss, if you choose to say.** Before the one scene in the year that touches death directly, the guide will ask you, one to one and never in the circle, whether there is a recent loss you would want that day planned around. You can decline to say, and nothing is written either way.
- **If you are matched with a mentor.** The guide can see that contact exists and how often, never what it says. You, your parent and the mentor sign the boundaries together. Your parent is told who any guest speaker is and when they come.
- **Your Growth Record, in the Compass.** The one record here that is built to leave with you. It works differently from everything else on this list, so it has its own section below.
- **The agreements record, if you ever reach a Stop.** Our studio agreements run on a ladder: a Pause, then a Stop, then a Strike. The Stop and the Strike are the two rungs that make paper. A Stop note says what happened and goes home the same day, you fill it out with your guide, and the line about coming back is yours in your own words. A Strike letter lists the dates of the three Stops. Your character contract is yours, in your handwriting, and a copy stays with Jenna, who runs the school, while you are working it. All of it records a choice and never a judgement about who you are, the count clears at the start of each year, and none of it goes on a transcript or travels with your Growth Record.
- **What is never kept.** Scores. Rankings. Assessments of your character written by anyone but you. Any note about you that you have not read. Any file that follows you past this year.

You can ask to read anything written about you, at any time, and the guide will show you. If you think a note is wrong, say so, and it gets corrected. That includes a Pause, a Stop or a Strike: if you think a call was wrong, say so, and it can come off - off the note and off the

count. You do not have to be calm about it. A learner who is angry at an unfair call is giving us information, not failing a condition.

That is the whole of it. “No surveillance” is a promise about this list, and the list is short on purpose.

The Growth Record, the Launch, and whether any of this counts on paper

You are sixteen to eighteen, so a fair question about any year of your life is whether it counts on paper. Here is the straight answer.

The Compass holds a record called your **Growth Record**, and the whole design of it is that you own it and the studio does not. The app is a lens, not a vault: you hold the keys from the first day, and a guide is a guest whose access ends when the relationship does, which for a launching learner is the Launch. A school cannot lose, withhold or hold hostage a record it never held in the first place.

It has two faces, and you control which one anybody sees.

- **The Journey view** is the whole trail, in order, with the slow parts and the stalls in it. It stays private. It is yours. Reading it at the start of the Launch is your invitation: alone, or with the guide if you want company.
- **The Portrait view** is the one you would hand a college, an employer or a programme. It is framed as what you can actually do, and **you choose what goes into it, piece by piece.** Nobody assembles your Portrait for you, and nobody sends it anywhere without you.

One rule holds across both, and it is built into the thing rather than promised about it: growth here is only ever shown as **movement compared to your own earlier self.** Never a grade. Never a score. Never set beside another learner.

And the honest limit, which you should hear from us rather than discover. The part that lets the record physically leave - a real export, readable by a human, held in your hands - **is not finished yet.** It is being built. Until it exists, nobody walks the Launch, because a ceremony that hands you something that is not there is not a ceremony. That is a rule the programme put on itself before any learner was in the room.

The Launch, and what is promised. If you are leaving at the end of this year, the Helm’s last session flows into the Launch: a rite in three movements, where the ending is named out loud, you decide what to do with the Mantle, you leave one small thing for the room, and you step

over a real threshold into a circle of adults who receive you as one. That is promised, and so is this: the Launch is built to be sad as well as glad, on purpose. It names that this was your home and that you are leaving it, and holds that without hurrying. If no family is in the room, the tribe is your people, said now and not on the day. Two things are conditional, and you should hear them now. The Launch cannot be walked until the Growth Record export exists. And the deep version of each heavy session runs only when a second adult is in the room; otherwise the lighter version runs, and that is the floor working, not you missing something. What is never conditional: the door stays unlocked from your side, nobody will call you back, and a launched learner who never returns is a success.

Two more things, said plainly. High-school credit is tracked separately, and it is the one record other people read as a routine matter, which is the honest exception to the first promise; if this is your last year, the guide will walk the credit close-out with you rather than leave it to the last week. And a transcript from a studio like this one is not yet a thing every college recognises; the bridge to dual enrollment is real work and we will do it alongside you rather than pretending it is already finished.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

The Helm runs the full Vibrant Life year, mid-August to late May, on the school's calendar rather than a tidy one of its own, and it takes the same shape as Origin: seven sessions with a break between each, thirty-one weeks of session work, plus the three-week Open Waters tail, for thirty-four program weeks in all. The sessions are **not** equal lengths. They are set by where the breaks fall. The last session is the harvest, and for a leaving learner it flows into the Launch.

The Helm 2029-2030. A program week is Monday to Thursday: two guide mornings (Tuesday and Thursday), two the learners run themselves (Monday and Wednesday), and Friday fallow.

Session	Dates	Weeks
S1 The Mantle	Aug 13 - Sep 6	4
session break	Sep 10 - 13	
S2 No Easy Answers	Sep 17 - Oct 18	5
session break	Oct 22 - 25	
S3 The Ripple	Oct 29 - Nov 15	3
Thanksgiving	Nov 19 - 23	
S4 The Stage	Nov 26 - Dec 13	3
Winter break	Dec 17 - 28	
S5 The Arena of Voices	Dec 31 - Feb 7	6
session break	Feb 11 - 14	
S6 The Bridge	Feb 18 - Mar 28	6
session break	Apr 1 - 4	

Session	Dates	Weeks
S7 The Council	Apr 8 - May 2	4
Open Waters (flex tail)	May 6 - May 23	3

Five Mondays inside sessions are holidays - Labor Day (Sep 3) in S1, the second Monday of October (Oct 8) in S2, Veterans Day observed (Nov 12) in S3, MLK Day (Jan 21) in S5, Presidents Day (Feb 18) on S6's first day - and a Monday here is a self-run morning rather than a guided one. Two guide days are holidays: Election Day, Tue Nov 6, in S3, and New Year's Day, Tue Jan 1, in S5's first week as projected; whether the studio observes Election Day is decided before S3 opens.

> *The dates above are Origin's 2027-2028 shape laid onto a start of Monday, August 13, 2029, with the real Thanksgiving week. They are projected, not set. One thing a real calendar will almost certainly move: as printed, S5 opens on Monday, December 31 with New Year's Day on its first Tuesday, so the winter break likely sits a week later than printed. Jenna, who runs the school, sets the real dates; confirm before anything is printed for a family.*

The content below has not yet been laid onto these weeks. The sessions were planned at three, six, three, six, three, three and six weeks; the calendar gives four, five, three, three, six, six and four plus the tail. Where a session has more weeks than its plan, the extra weeks are named below as not yet planned, and nothing is set for them, because a week nobody has listed is the week that gets quietly filled. Where a session has fewer, the plan says so, and what moves is for the voices who own the material to decide, not this book to decide quietly. The Stage is the sharpest case: six weeks of plan, three on the calendar, and the death scene inside it.

Every session ends into a break, so every session carries the same two seams. On the last guided day, the carry-out: the pace question, the harvest, and the closing minute at session scale. On the first guided day back, the re-thread. The re-ask is rarer and is asked where there is still time to act on the answer: at the winter break, after the Stage, and on the year-close day. The agreements are open for reopening at every session's close too - say so on the last guided day, every time, so the handle is real and not only promised in week one.

On the very first day, name the destination out loud. This is the single most important framing move of the year:

> SAY
>
> "In May you will sit with your people and make a hard call in the open. We call it the Council. Some of you will then go out the door into your own lives - that's the Launch. Everything between now and then is getting ready to sit in that chair and mean it."

No week count in the line: the count is not settled, and a date that moves is a promise broken. Once the mountain is named on day one, every session becomes a rung toward it. The reasoning work is how the captain thinks. The empathy work is how the captain feels the cost. The mentorship work is learning the terrain from those who walked it. The leadership work is how the captain holds the room. Give them the mountain first, and the whole year points somewhere.

Three threads run through the whole year and give it a spine:

1. **The destination**, named day one (the Council, and the Launch).
2. **The Mantle**, one physical object taken up in Session 1 and carried to the end.
3. **The Vineyard**, the un-useful joy, tended for years, ripening now.

The year's daily frame: the no-win call

The daily ritual of The Helm is the no-win scenario. It opens every guide day after the settle and the circle, because you cannot stand inside something that cannot be won while nobody in the room knows you are tired. Name it plainly as the same muscle the learners have built all along: small choices in Origin, standing inside big questions in The Forge, and now the hard call inside a situation that cannot be cleanly won.

The famous move in the old story - reprogram the test, beat the unbeatable - is the bait, not the lesson. For near-adults months from the real world, the deeper truth is this: the test is not whether you can always find the clever third option. It is who you are when there is no third option. Sometimes the freighter dies: sometimes there is no option where nobody loses something. So teach both halves. Half the wisdom is finding the third door when it is really there. The other half is knowing when there isn't one, choosing anyway from principle, naming the cost, and not losing yourself carrying it. The highest thing this whole three-year arc can produce is not "the learner found the clever way out." It is: the learner faced something that could not be won, made the hard call from principle, named what it cost, and did not lose themselves doing it.

The safety floor, fullest here

This year has the heaviest material in the whole program, so the floor is built up thickest. Do not treat the floor as the brake on honesty. The floor is what lets the room go to hard places and come back. Honest-and-held changes a person; honest-and-abandoned wounds them. The whole difference is that one word: held.

The floor has these parts, and they are non-negotiable:

- **The settle, the way down, the close-return, the closing minute.** Described in full in Part 1; the learner reads the same words you do. Every heavy day opens with the settle (settle the room before you stir it), has a short way down in the middle of the work, and ends with the close-return said in its fixed words, so people land back in the present. Fix your own wording for the settle in the first week, write it down, and do not improve it, because the sameness is the medicine: a settle improvised fresh never becomes the reflex a body drops into, and if it goes stale to you, that is it working. Run the closing minute at the close of every guide day, light days included; "take your closing minute" is the whole prompt, and you never ask what came up. A tired guide cuts these first because they feel like overhead. They are not overhead. They are the floor.
- **Stepping out and back.** There is a named place a learner can go to, set up in week one, and they never have to ask. Coming back in costs nothing - they slip back during a soft moment, no scene, no acknowledgment demanded.
- **A crew that holds each other.** On heavy days every learner is paired with one other learner who simply notices them. Frame it as a crew, always - never "assigned to watch you flood." A crew keeps the person at the centre the one steering. A watch set on someone turns them into the thing being watched, and the room into the hero of their story. Keep them the hero.
- **A second adult present for the heaviest sessions.** Three sessions carry material heavy enough that one adult cannot both hold the room's deliberation and catch the one learner quietly going under. On the deep day of those three, a second adult is required in the room - not for childcare, but as a second pair of eyes whose only job is to leave with the learner who needs to leave, at that learner's pace, so you never have to choose between the room and the wound. The three are Session 2 (the heaviest dilemmas), Session 4 (the death scene in *Our Town*), and Session 7 (the public Council). The second adult is another trained adult: a co-op parent who has done the safety briefing, or another adult freed for that hour, never one of the learners. Name it as a precondition, not a hope. If a second adult genuinely cannot be secured for a given heavy week, the deep block for that week lightens or defers -

the lighter version runs, and the deep version waits until the room can be held. That is the floor working, not the guide failing.

- **The referral pathway, in plain terms.** You are a life-coach and mentor, not a licensed clinician. This year surfaces real clinical material - grief around mortality, shame, hard days - more and earlier than any prior year. Your job is not to treat it. It is to recognize when something is past coaching, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast. Route now, do not "work it in a session," if you see or hear any of these: any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here; abuse, neglect, or someone hurting them; a crisis happening right now: panic, a flashback, feeling cut off from their own body, or distress you cannot reach; signs of something going wrong with eating; a crisis with drugs or alcohol; a threat to someone else; something past an ordinary hard day: it keeps going, and it is getting in the learner's way. When in doubt, route. Being sure is a clinician's job, not yours. Stay with the learner, never leave them alone in crisis, move to the designated quiet space, be calm and present, do not ask for details or counsel. The referral roster must be built real - real names and current numbers - before Session 1 runs, and the one line that must never stay blank is a named, warm-referral therapist arranged in advance. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, including you; suspected abuse or neglect gets reported, ideally within twenty-four hours, and you do not need proof, because the law gives the judging to the state. This duty does not give you a key to the Log: you do not read it, so it cannot be a source; what the duty reaches is what a learner tells you, shows you or hands you, and what you see and hear in the room. Say that distinction out loud on day one. 988 is the crisis line; keep those numbers current and on paper, because in a crisis the phone in your hand is already doing something else, and a number you have to search for is a number you do not call. The pathway runs across breaks, not only on program days, and the learner is told so before each one.
- **Keep confidences safe.** Say the privacy words on day one, woven into the promises you make each other, and say them as written rather than improvising a warmer version, because a learner who hears a different wording than the one they read goes looking for the seam:

> SAY
>
> "Almost everything you write and say here is yours. Your Captain's Log, nobody reads - including me, and I won't go looking. What I can't keep private is a short list, and I'd rather you hear it now than find out later: if you're in danger, if someone's hurting you, or if something's going on that's bigger than I can hold here. That's when I bring in real help, and usually that means a call home too. I'll tell you when I'm doing it. That's not breaking trust - it's what care actually looks like."

Those are the same promises that are on the learner's privacy page in Part 1, in your own voice. Said up front, that is a promise kept. Said only in the moment, it feels like betrayal.

- **Material is chosen, not sprung; opt-in by readiness.** The heaviest content is previewed, alternates are chosen before the day and never improvised, because an alternate chosen on the day is chosen in front of the learner who needs it and announces them. No learner is required to disclose anything about their own life to take part. The lighter version of the whole year is the honorable first pass, because a floor never run has never been tested and the first tribe is the test. The full version is a choice a rested tribe makes on purpose, before the year, never something a tired room slides into, because exhaustion decides late, after the heavy day is on the calendar, while readiness decides early.

Leadership styles taught by example

In the leadership work you will use well-known ship captains and public leaders as examples - different styles of leading, all real. Present them plainly, as public teaching examples. "Here are four real captains with four different styles; which do you lead like?" is a teaching device, nothing more. They are not insider lore and they are not personas giving advice. They are examples a learner can look up on their own, the way you would study any public leader.

Holding a "no" - three beats

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies in the single moment a learner actually says no. If that moment collapses into invisible opt-out - silence, the activity just continues around them - the learner is protected by being erased from the room. So hold a no in three beats, and you can run them under load:

1. **Receive the no, whole.** "Okay. You're not doing this one." Honor it *before* any curiosity, so your curiosity never lands as a lever.

2. **Offer the door once, and don't push it.** "That no stands, and it's done. When you've worked out what's behind it, the tribe will want to hear it. Not me - them. And not today." Hold both halves or you have turned the practice into a toll: the reasoning is genuinely owed to the room, and it is genuinely not owed in the moment. If a learner never comes back to it, that is between them and the tribe, and it is not yours to collect.
3. **Keep them inside the encounter.** "Come sit with me - you don't have to do the thing." Removing the task is not the same as removing the person.

Your curious question stays a mirror, never a way to scare someone into yes. Ask "when do you think you'll first run into this for real?" - not "what happens the first time you need this and no one is beside you?" The first opens a door with curiosity; the second forecasts them alone and unequipped, which lands on an anxious learner as "you'll be sorry." And "the right kind of scared" is the learner's to name about themselves. It is never yours to assign to them. You have a voice. You never have a veto.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

This year asks the most of the guide, too. Holding hard material costs the holder, and the whole floor depends on you having enough reserve left to notice the one learner going under.

- **Run your own floor.** Do your own settle, your own way down at day's end, your own closing minute. This is safety instrumentation, not self-care - a guide whose own body is flooded cannot run the watch-and-pivot. The room reads your nervous system faster than any lesson plan can counter.
- **Debrief after every heavy day.** After each of the three heaviest deep days, debrief with a peer or supervisor before the next heavy session. Do not carry it alone.
- **A second adult on the heaviest days** protects you as much as the room.
- **Lightening or deferring is honorable.** If the load is too much in a given week, the lighter version is the floor working. What you can hold sets how many learners are in the room, and both come before money, because a learner enrolled on coverage not yet secured is one the floor cannot hold, and the day it fails is the day you find out.
- **Your fallow day is fallow too, and so are the breaks.** Protected, not on-call. The learner's page says plainly that you are not reachable over a break, so you never have to improvise that limit on the last guided day; what you say aloud before each break is who is: the one adult outside the room, and 988. Every session here ends into a break: the September break after the Mantle, the October break after No Easy Answers, Thanksgiving after the Ripple, the two-week winter break after the Stage and its death scene, the February break after the

Arena of Voices while a mentor's silence may still be landing, the April break after the Bridge, Open Waters and then summer, and for some the Launch, after the Council. Say it on the last guided day, every time.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below gives you: what it's for, a plain word for the learner, the flow, things you might say, the settle and closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need. Each session header carries its calendar weeks and projected dates; the week labels inside a session count from that session's first week.

One word about words. Part 1 said the Log is kept however you hold it, and that holds all year. When the sessions below say write, draft, or read, they mean put it in your Log and go back to it, in whatever form yours takes. The book says write because it is the shortest word, not because it is the only way. The same holds for stand, walk, speak, perform, wear, and cross: they mean take part in the way your body takes part. And anything the room listens to has a transcript in the room; anything the room reads can be heard. Both are on the table for everyone before anyone needs them; nobody has to ask.

Session 1 - The Mantle (four weeks, Aug 13 - Sep 6)

What it's for. To open the year by meeting imposter feeling honestly - naming it as the felt sensation of growth, not a defect - and to take up the Mantle you will carry all year. The imposter's lie is "everyone else belongs here and I snuck in." The truth is that accomplished people feel it too, and for many people it fades with acting, not with proving. For some it stays, and they act with it there.

For the learner. "Who am I to make hard calls?" Most people feel that knot when they reach past what they can already do, including people who have done a great deal. This session names that feeling and puts something beside it: real evidence of hard things you have already done, pulled from your own record. Then there is a rite, the Mantle, where you may say aloud what you are taking up for the year. For some people worthiness arrives after the acting. For some it doesn't, and they act anyway. Both are the year.

Here is the whole of it, said now. You will not be asked to share a time you felt like a fraud. The adults do that part - the guide and a mentor say theirs, specifically - and you receive it. If you want one of yours in the room, you put it on a card with no name and the guide reads it as "someone here once felt." Nobody can see who wrote and who did not. Right after, same morning, you build your Evidence File from any real proof you have: the Origin portfolio if you were here for it, your Forge project, work from outside the studio. In the third week there is a short rite. You'll be asked to say one sentence, in your own words, about what you're taking up this year. You can say it to the room, say it quietly to your chosen witness only, put it on a card the witness reads out, or say nothing and still take the mantle. The mantle is a real object; you take it up yourself, worn, held, or set in your hands. One person you chose says back what they saw. If you don't take it up this session, nothing in the year closes to you; you can take it up any week in a walk-in, and the Council is open to you either way. Stepping out mid-rite costs nothing.

The flow.

Weeks 1-4 · Aug 13 - Sep 6 · off: Mon Sep 3, Labor Day. The plan below describes three weeks. **Week 4 is part of the session and is not yet planned; nothing is set for it and nothing is owed in it.**

- Week 1 opens the year: the exit ramp built and walked before any promise is asked for; the privacy words said as written, and the one adult outside the room named; name the destination (the Council and the Launch), introduce the no-win frame as the same muscle from Origin and The Forge, re-open the Vineyard ("the part of the week that is yours to love"), and name imposter feeling as universal and as a growth signal. On the deep day, you and an invited mentor model imposter feeling - genuinely and specifically ("here is a time I felt like a fraud"). The learners *receive* it. That alone teaches "accomplished people feel this too."
- Week 2 turns "who am I to do this?" into "why not you?" and builds the Evidence File - real proof of competence, pulled forward from the Origin portfolio for a returner, or from whatever real proof a learner has: their Log, work from elsewhere, a thing they built. Each learner may also choose a real act, this week, that scares them a little - take a real chair, make a real call, ship a real thing - and see what is on the far side. Some find worthiness there; some find they did a thing; both are true.
- Week 3 is the Mantle rite, in four movements, all told to the learner before the day. **The threshold:** each learner names, in their own words and their own way - spoken, signed, or put on a card the witness reads out - what they are taking up ("I am someone who can hold

a hard call"), claimed, not conferred. Saying it while not yet fully believing it *is* the rite. **The object:** they take up the mantle, worn, held, or set in their hands, and find the Evidence File as its lining - proof, in the pocket, that they have already done hard things. **The witness:** a witness the learner chose reflects the crossing back ("I saw you take that up"). **The wearing:** the mantle is not taken off at day's end. It becomes the year's through-line, worn toward the Council and the Launch. Ask the pace question at the close, and run the closing minute at session scale.

This is the rebuilt session - read this carefully. The old version had "everyone shares a time they felt like a fraud, going around the circle." That is gone, on purpose. Shame and imposter feeling are not the same emotion. Imposter feeling ("I don't belong here yet") is generative. Public shame disclosure in a peer group, at the age of peak peer-sensitivity, can wound lastingly - and opting out of a shame ritual in front of peers becomes its own quiet shame event. So the structure is fixed:

- The dissolving power comes from **adults modeling, learners receiving** - not from any learner being required to share.
- No circle-round, no going-around.
- If a learner *wants* to share, it is **non-attributed** - put on a card in any form a learner can make alone (written, typed, or recorded alone in the quiet space) and always read aloud in the guide's voice, with no name ("someone here once felt…"). The guide's voice is what keeps abstention invisible for a learner who cannot write.
- **Abstention is invisible.** In a "receive, then optionally make a card" structure, no one can see who chose not to. That is the only way opt-out is real in a peer room. The cards are read once and then gone; nobody keeps them or matches a hand to a name.
- The Evidence File comes immediately after, same session. Never leave a room having surfaced shame without building the counterweight of real evidence of competence.

Things to say. - "In May you make a hard call in the open, before your people. Everything from here is getting ready to sit in that chair and mean it." - "That feeling of not-belonging-yet? Accomplished people feel it too. It doesn't mean you snuck in. It means you're reaching." - "Why not you? If not you, who?" - "You don't have to feel ready to act. Many find the feeling comes after. If it doesn't, you still did the thing, and the thing was real." - (At the rite) "I saw you take that up."

The settle and the closing minute. Open with the settle - shame lives in the body (heat, dropped gaze, a curled spine), so settle the room before you touch the material. Go in small steps: the adults speak first and nothing is asked of anyone at the start, so the counterweight

of evidence is built before anything heavy is held. Close with the close-return. This is an opening session, so the closing minute matters; "take your closing minute" is the whole prompt, and "I don't know yet" is a real close.

Watch-fors. A learner who dips into shame needs the room to treat it as normal and needs the exit ramp they can use without asking. What someone puts on a card can be bigger than a card; the referral pathway is live before this session runs. Guard the order so that any modeling is never the price of admission to the Mantle; the evidence of worth must be reachable by the learner who says nothing aloud.

What you'll need. An invited mentor for the modeling; cards for optional non-attributed sharing, in any form a learner can make alone; each learner's own record for the Evidence File, in the form it was made, with a transcript for any recorded part; the physical mantle object, one that can be worn, held, or placed beside a learner, and a witness each learner chooses for the rite; the exit ramp and quiet space set up; the two names, written: the one adult outside the room, and the person who takes the child; the referral pathway live.

Session 2 - No Easy Answers (five weeks, Sep 17 - Oct 18) - one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To learn to reason through real moral dilemmas from principle, out loud, without an answer key. The world does not hand you the right answer. The win is not the verdict - it is the quality of the reasoning and the honesty about the cost. This is how the captain who will hold the Council learns to think.

For the learner. Some questions have no clean right answer, and pretending they do is a lie. This session you practice standing inside one long enough to reason from your own principles instead of grabbing the exit. The cases come through story and real history, so you can think about heavy things at full weight without anyone saying anything about their own life.

Here is what the stories touch, said now so none of it is a surprise: a person who wants to end their own suffering; being forced; being pressed to be like everyone else; and the Dred Scott case, which is not the other side of a hard call but a real court reasoning its way into evil - we study it to learn the difference. The two heaviest weeks are previewed, each has a lighter alternate ready, and a second adult is in the room: not to watch you, but so that if one person needs to leave, someone goes with them and the room still stands. You can step out any time, no reason owed. The harvest is a reasoned position on a hard case. "I can name the two goods that collide here and I haven't decided" is a reasoned position.

The flow.

Weeks 5-9 · Sep 17 - Oct 18 · off: Mon Oct 8, Indigenous Peoples' Day / Columbus Day. The plan below describes six weeks for a five-week session. **One week of it has no home on the calendar yet**; what moves is for the voices who own the material.

This session opens after the first break of the year: re-thread first. The method is moral dilemmas told through allegory, meaning a story that stands in for a real thing (well-known dramatic episodes), tied to real historical cases - personhood (paired with the Dred Scott case), due process under fear (paired with McCarthyism), loyalty versus truth (paired with whistleblowing). Weeks 1 through 3 build the reasoning craft through progressively harder cases. Weeks 4 and 5 are the heaviest cases, previewed and alternated, with a second adult present; ask the pace question at the close of week 4, while there is still time to act on it. Week 6 is the harvest: each learner makes a reasoned position on a hard case, held from principle - not "won" - and an undecided position honestly reasoned is a whole harvest. Run the closing minute at session scale on the last guided day.

The spine of the session is the **Reasoning Standard** - five structural questions the reasoning must answer, none of which is "what is the right answer." Use it to coach, to self-assess, and to hold yourself to as well:

1. **Principles named** - which two or more genuine goods conflict here? (If there is only one real principle, it is not a dilemma - it may be a rationalized wrong. Say which.)
2. **Cost owned** - what does your path cost, and to whom? (A path that claims to be free is hiding its cost.)
3. **Steelman survived** - can you state the position you rejected well enough that its holder would say "yes, that's it"?
4. **Reversibility** - would you accept this reasoning if you were the person it costs?
5. **Framework visible** - are you reasoning through consequences, duty, character, or care? What does a different lens see that yours misses?

Two guardrails to teach. There is a well-known map of how moral reasoning grows up, made by a psychologist named Kohlberg; it describes *arguments*, never ranks *people*, and the map itself is argued over - say so. And teach the distinction between a genuine dilemma and a rationalized wrong. Some paired cases are real dilemmas. Some are not - Dred Scott is the study of how a system reasoned itself into evil, not "the other side of a hard call." A curriculum that cannot tell those apart teaches false equivalence. Teaching learners to tell them apart teaches the sharpest blade of the year. Real cases get real study - primary voices, the

human cost named - or the pairing drops to allegory only. Honor the reality, or do not borrow its weight.

Things to say. - "The world doesn't come with an answer key. The win here isn't the answer - it's how well you reasoned and how honestly you named the cost." - "A story that stands in for the real thing isn't the watered-down version. It's the tool that lets us think about the hardest things at full weight, and nothing about your own life has to come into the room." - "Say the strongest version of the side you disagree with - well enough that someone who holds it would say, yes, that's exactly it." - "Dred Scott isn't the other side of a dilemma. It's how a whole system reasoned itself into evil. Learning to tell those apart is the whole game." - (In the heaviest weeks) "Today's story touches death and the choice to end suffering. You can step out any time, you don't owe anyone a reason, and there's water and a chair by the window."

The settle and the closing minute. Every heavy day: the settle to open, a short way down between hard passages (thirty seconds: feet on the floor or hands on the chair, look around the room, one breath), the close-return in its fixed words. Pre-brief before every flagged-heavy episode - name the terrain, name the exit, name that no reason is owed. This is arrival, not ambush, and it does the most for the least of anything you do. The dilemma work is an opening; close it with the closing minute (the feeling-side twin of the Reasoning Standard - reason the hard call, *and* re-cross what it stirred).

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the heaviest deep days. Preview-and-alternate the heaviest episodes - assisted death, coercion, identity and conformity - with alternates chosen before the day, never improvised. The dilemma can be unflinching about the world; the learner's own interior is never required as material. If the care starts to sound like a prediction, as if the room expects you to fall apart, say less about the net and keep every bit of it in place.

What you'll need. The allegory episodes and their alternates pre-selected, each captioned, with a transcript, and audio-described where a described version exists - where none does, the guide says aloud what is on the screen as it plays; the paired real cases with primary sources, in print and audio; the Reasoning Standard on one page and read aloud once; a second adult secured for the heavy weeks; the settle, the way down, the close-return and the exit ramp in place; the referral pathway live.

Session 3 - The Ripple (three weeks, Oct 29 - Nov 15, ends into Thanksgiving)

What it's for. To learn consequence-thinking - looking one, two, three moves downstream of a choice, and being honest that you cannot see all the way. Good captains think in ripples, not single points. This is a deliberately lighter, playful beat between the two heaviest sessions.

For the learner. A hard call doesn't end when you make it. It sets things in motion - some you meant, some you didn't. This session is about looking downstream before you act, and staying humble about the part of the river you can't see yet.

The flow.

Weeks 10-12 · Oct 29 - Nov 15 · on a guide day: Tue Nov 6, Election Day, observance decided before the session · off: Mon Nov 12, Veterans Day observed · ends into Thanksgiving.

The tools are games and maps: the Ripple Board (map the first-, second-, and third-order effects of a choice), the Monkey's Paw (every wish granted with an unforeseen cost - the shadow side of "solutions"), counterfactual history (change one thing, follow the ripples), and the Pre-Mortem (imagine the choice already failed - why?). Week 1 opens with the games, week 2 goes downstream two and three moves, week 3 harvests a real decision traced forward, with blind spots owned and agency kept.

This session opens after the break: re-thread first. Because it is medium-weight and safe, it is one of the two homes for meeting a hard thing with only the ordinary supports rather than the full net - the guide present, the exit available, but the visible net turned down. This is chosen and named by the learner, never sprung, for a learner who chooses it, launching this year or not, and never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough. Reduce the visible net, never the floor's availability. The last guided day of this session is the last before Thanksgiving: ask the pace question, run the closing minute at session scale, and say aloud who is reachable over the break, and that you are not.

Things to say. - "Every choice sends ripples. Chase the cascade - then what? And then what?" - "The wish always comes with a twist. What's the shadow of this solution?" - "You can't see all the way downstream, and pretending you can is its own mistake. The move is: act wisely, watch for the ripples, adjust."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close even though the day is light - a light session still bookends. Closing minute as usual.

Watch-fors. Consequence-thinking can tip into anxiety ("what if everything goes wrong"). Always pair it with agency - "and here is the move you can still make." The point is wiser

action, not fear of acting. Keep this session light on purpose; do not import heavy material into the room's breath between the two hardest sessions. No second adult needed.

What you'll need. The Ripple Board setup, said aloud as each ripple goes up; a Monkey's Paw story or two, read aloud or with a transcript; counterfactual prompts; each learner's own Forge project for the Pre-Mortem, or any real decision of their own for a learner who joined this year.

Session 4 - The Stage (three weeks, Nov 26 - Dec 13, ends into the winter break) - one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To feel a hard call from inside the lives it touches, through theatre - and to practice the discipline of stepping fully into another life and cleanly back out again. The distance of the stage is a safety feature, like allegory: you can *be* the person who makes the other choice.

For the learner. To make a hard call well, you have to feel it from inside the lives it touches. Theatre is a way to practice that from a safe distance: you try a person on, then you step out of them, and stepping out whole matters as much as stepping in. Performing is always a choice; watching is equal, and the harvest is yours in either shape: a moment you performed, or a moment you witnessed and can say what the other person carried.

One play, *Our Town*, has a scene where a young woman who has died comes back to relive one ordinary day. That is the one place this year where the story does not stand between you and the thing, because death on a stage is death. So, said now: a second adult is in the room that day, there is a named exit for that scene, and if you have lost someone recently and would want the day planned around you, tell the guide once, one to one, any time before that week. You decide what to say and whether to; nobody goes looking. Every role is chosen. You can perform, hand a role to the tribe, watch, or decline.

The flow.

> *Weeks 13-15 · Nov 26 - Dec 13 · ends into the winter break.* The plan below describes six weeks for a three-week session, with the death scene inside it. **Three weeks of it have no home on the calendar yet.** This is the one re-cut that must not be done quietly: the voices who own the Stage and the safety floor decide what a three-week Stage holds, and whether the death scene can sit this close to two weeks with the guide unreachable.

Warm-ups and improv open it (week 1), after the re-thread. Monologue work follows - each learner finds or writes a monologue from someone facing a hard call and gives that truth from the inside, in voice, sign, or a recording; performing is voluntary, witnessing is equal (week 2). Then the keystone text, *Our Town*, and its question: "Do any human beings ever realize life while they live it?" Emily returns from death to relive one ordinary day (week 3, the death-scene deep day; run it on the Tuesday, so the held day is the Thursday and no one carries it alone into a weekend). Then Forum Theatre (weeks 4-5): act out a hard-call scene, then let the room stop it and try a different choice - deliberation made physical, which pays off directly in the Council; a scene can be played seated, voiced, or signed, and the stop is a word, a gesture, or a raised card, agreed before the first scene so stopping costs nobody anything. Ask the pace question at the close of week 4. Week 6 harvests a moment of empathy - stepping fully into another life and back out whole, performed or witnessed - and the re-ask (*is this still yours?*), answered one at a time in the walk-in, never round the circle. The last guided day is the last before the two-week winter break: say aloud who is reachable across it, that 988 is always open, that you are not until January, and that the pathway stays live the whole time. Run the closing minute at session scale.

Archetypes are taught as **doorways, not identities**: you try a way of being on; you are not it. "I encountered the Hero," never "I am the Hero."

Two closes are kept strictly separate here. **De-roling** closes a *role* - "that wasn't me." The **closing minute** closes a real *feeling* the role opened - "that was me, and I carry it, and I'm still here." Never de-role real grief. De-roling teaches "that wasn't me"; grief needs "that was me, and I am still here." Keep the line bright.

Things to say. - "You're not becoming this person. You're trying them on. It's a doorway, not who you are." - "Do any of us ever really realize life while we're living it? Every, every minute?" - (After an embodiment, the de-roling) "Say or sign your own name. Name three things true about your real life right now - I am [name], I am 17, it's Tuesday, I have soccer after this. Now shake out your hands, or whatever part of you moves, and feel what's under you - the floor, the chair, your own hands." - (For real grief that surfaces) "That was real. That was you. Let's not push it out - it can stay, and you're still here."

The settle and the closing minute. The settle to open, a short way down in the middle of the work, the close-return at the end, every heavy day. De-role after *every* embodiment, with the real mechanic (say or sign your name, three true things about your real life, remove the prop, shake out, feel what is under you) - not once per session, every single time a body wears another life, because the nervous system does not know a role is pretend; it runs the state for real. Then the closing minute for anything real the role opened.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the *Our Town* death-scene deep day - it is the one place this year's story-distance does not apply, because death on the stage *is* the real thing, and it lands straight on anyone carrying a recent loss, with no story in between. Ask, before that week, one to one and never in the circle, whether anyone has lost someone recently and would want the scene planned around them. The learner decides what to tell you; you do not go looking, and nothing is written either way. This is a judgment made before the day, never improvised, with a previewed exit named for that scene specifically. Roles are always chosen; a role can be given to the tribe only, witnessed rather than performed, or declined. Protect the theatre-as-play as genuine joy, not only a safety warm-up, and keep the Vineyard distinct from the de-roling toolkit, because the moment the thing you love is used to bring you down from a role it has been made useful, and that is the day it dies.

What you'll need. Monologue sources in print, large print, and audio; the *Our Town* text in a form each learner can read or hear, any film of it captioned with a transcript, and the death scene described in words before it runs; a second adult for the death scene; whatever learners chose to tell you about a recent loss; a previewed exit; the de-roling space and mechanic; the settle, the way down, the close-return and the exit ramp; the referral pathway live.

Session 5 - The Arena of Voices (six weeks, Dec 31 - Feb 7)

What it's for. To learn from real adults walking the road ahead - professional mentors and guest speakers - and to learn the real skill of being mentored well. No one navigates alone. Being mentored can be a threshold. Some feel seen by it; some get a useful answer and nothing more; both count.

For the learner. Some adults are further down your road, and a conversation with one can be worth a lot. This session you learn how to be mentored: come with one real question you actually want answered, ask it, and say thank you afterward. Two honest things before you write to anyone. A lot of people won't answer. That says nothing about you; busy people are busy, and silence says nothing about your worth. And one-to-one mentors may not happen this year, because the structure that keeps that door safe is still being built. If it is not ready, nobody is passed over: the guest speakers and your own interview are the whole session, not a lesser one. Any mentoring match can be ended with one word to the guide, no reason owed. "I reached out and nothing came back" is a real harvest.

The flow.

Weeks 16-21 · Dec 31 - Feb 7 · off: Tue Jan 1, New Year's Day (a guide day as projected; the real break likely moves), Mon Jan 21, MLK Day · no break inside this session. The plan below describes three weeks. **Weeks 4, 5 and 6 of the session are not yet planned; nothing is set for them and nothing is owed in them.** The mentor's reply that comes when it comes is the waiting this session already holds.

This session opens after the winter break: the re-thread first, as a whole first morning, because two weeks away after the Stage is the longest stretch of the year with no one in the room. Week 1 teaches the art of being mentored (prepare, ask, follow up) and drafts real interview questions. Week 2 the voices arrive - a Boise guest speaker who has made real hard calls, and each learner's own informational interview. A question sent to a busy adult is answered when it is answered, and the week you spend not hearing back is this session's work, not a gap before it. Week 3 harvests a real conversation and the honest account of what it opened, or "I asked, and nothing has come yet," and closes the loop with genuine thanks; the thank-you can go to someone who never replied. Ask the pace question, run the closing minute at session scale, and say aloud who is reachable over the break that follows, since a silence may still be landing.

The two-track design (binding). A guest speaker is a window; a one-to-one mentor is a door. Secure them differently.

- **Guest speakers (the window): buildable now, with a modest policy.** Guide present for the entire visit (this alone satisfies the never-alone rule); a public, observable setting; a short expectations sheet the speaker acknowledges (topic scope, no private contact with learners, no photos without consent); parent notification of who and when. No background check is required for a one-time supervised group speaker - the supervision *is* the control, and requiring checks would kill the ability to bring interesting people in. Watch the conversion point: a speaker who starts contacting a learner afterward has walked through the door without being vetted for it - route any follow-up through the guide, which moves them to the mentor track.
- **One-to-one professional mentors (the door): not cleared until the container exists.** Observable channel only - no private messages, personal social media, or off-platform contact; the guide sees that contact exists and how often, never reads the content for assessment. Never-alone satisfied by structure - default remote and monitored; in person only with the guide present or in a public setting, never a private residence or vehicle. A background check before first contact. Three-party informed consent (parent, learner, mentor) plus signed boundaries. A no-fault off-ramp - a learner ends or reports a match with one word to the guide, no reason owed, no confrontation. A written safeguarding and

mandatory-reporting policy authored once, on paper, before the first match. And a counsel review of Idaho duty-of-care, mandatory reporting, and liability. Build the container before the first match.

- **Reciprocity - honor the givers, never mine them.** Pay real honoraria and cover costs (a waived fee is accepted only if freely offered, never solicited). Offer a menu of depths - one informational interview, a short arc, or a sustained mentorship - with the one-off honored identically to the year-long. Bounded terms and a dignified exit. The teen arrives prepared. Close the loop: thank them, tell them what their gift did, ask whether it served them too. A professional's hard-call story is a gift, never the price of admission - especially one that sits close to a wound, which is invited freely and never required as content. The mentor is not the load-bearing safeguarding adult; route weight it wasn't built for to the guide.

Source mentors warmly, through communities that already hold relationship - the parent network, local professional and civic bodies - never by cold approach, because a mentor reached through someone who already knows them has a relationship to answer to; a cold one has only the teenager, and a teenager is not a safeguard.

Things to say. - "A good question is a gift to the person answering it. Come with one you actually want answered." - (The no-answer line, said before any outreach) "If you reach out and hear nothing back - that is not a verdict on you. Busy people are busy. The non-response says nothing about your worth." - "Tell them what their answer did for you. Close the loop."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close. Closing minute for what a real conversation opened - or did not.

Watch-fors. The no-answer line matters: reaching out to an admired professional and being ignored is a real wound at this age. Teach "the non-response is not a verdict" *before* the outreach, not as consolation after. This is also the second of the two homes where a learner may choose to meet an ordinary-stakes hard thing with ordinary support - never a manufactured wound, chosen and named by the learner, and never pressed on a learner already carrying more than enough, because the point is an ordinary-sized hard thing met with ordinary support, not a wound made on purpose. Keep the mentor boundary bright.

What you'll need. The guest-speaker expectations sheet and parent notifications; the mentor-track container fully built before any one-to-one match; a reciprocity plan and honoraria budget; thank-you materials; notes or a transcript of the guest visit for any learner who needs one; the settle in place.

Session 6 - The Bridge (six weeks, Feb 18 - Mar 28)

What it's for. To practice leading peers and being led well. Leadership is stewardship, not command - the measure of a leader is what continues after they step back. This is where the Mantle is worn in the chair.

For the learner. The best captains lead toward not being needed: they build a crew that can go on without them. This session you may practice both seats, leading and being led, and both are the lesson. You'll also practice holding a real disagreement from the chair without deciding it. You will be disagreed with, and you will disappoint someone, in a small real thing, on purpose; that is the practice, not something going wrong. Every turn in the chair is a choice, and a turn that went badly is one of the most useful things that can happen here.

The flow.

Weeks 22-27 · Feb 18 - Mar 28 · off: Mon Feb 18, Presidents Day (the session's first day). The plan below describes three weeks. **Weeks 4, 5 and 6 of the session are not yet planned; nothing is set for them and nothing is owed in them.**

Re-thread first. Week 1 opens what leadership actually is (command versus stewardship, "lead toward your own unnecessity") and introduces rotating command. Week 2 is find-your-style, expedition leadership (plan and lead a real outing together, planned so every learner can go), and the hard parts - the loneliness of the final call, disappointing someone, being disagreed with, honoring the quiet leaders. Week 3 harvests a real act of leading peers *and* of being led well, or an honest account of a turn that went badly. Ask the pace question and run the closing minute at session scale on the last guided day.

Two kinds of leading are built here, and the second is the one the Council needs. **Rotating command** teaches you to sit in the chair and decide. **Rotating facilitation** teaches you to hold the room from beside it - to hold a question without answering it, so the group can. Each learner takes the convener's chair for a low-stakes *real* cohort disagreement and practices refusing to decide. Debrief warmly ("here's the moment you reached for the answer when your job was to hold the question").

Use well-known captains as public teaching examples of different styles - "which do you lead like?" Present them as public figures anyone can study, never as insider lore.

Things to say. - "Leadership is stewardship, not command. The measure of a leader is what keeps going when they step back." - "Lead toward your own unnecessity. A crew that no longer needs you is the goal, not a loss." - "Leading quietly from the back is a different kind of leadership, not a weaker one." - (The loneliness of command) "When the hard call comes, you

make it alone. The crew can advise; the crew can't decide. And here's the thing no one warns you about, and its answer: the captain with a life to go home to - the vineyard, the crew you love - makes better hard calls than the one who only has the chair."

The settle and the closing minute. Carry the settle and the close. The closing minute at every close.

Watch-fors. Guard against the room rewarding the loudest; name and honor the quiet leaders. Being led is a skill too - a learner who only ever leads has not finished the lesson, so rotate genuinely. Hold the hard parts internally, not for optics. In a mixed-age room, do not let the graduating learners' turns become the standard the younger ones measure themselves against - every turn in the chair is honored equally. Collaborative and safe by design; no second adult needed.

What you'll need. Real group tasks and a real outing to lead, planned so every learner can go; a low-stakes real disagreement for the facilitation practice; the settle in place.

Session 7 - The Council (four weeks, Apr 8 - May 2) - the harvest, one of the three heaviest

What it's for. To make a hard call in the open, before your people - reasoning from principle, naming the cost, honoring dissent, and either finding the third option or, when there isn't one, choosing anyway with your eyes open. This is the mountain the whole year climbed toward, named on day one. The learner wears the Mantle to hold the room.

For the learner. A council is not a debate to win. It is people of good faith reasoning together toward the best hard call they can make. They name the cost. They keep the dissent in the record. When the choice is a false either-or, they refuse it and look for the third way. When the either-or is real, they choose from principle and carry the cost. What you show is your reasoning, not a verdict on you.

Here is the whole of it, said now. The Council is public, your people in the room, and a second adult is there for the same reason as before. Four roles, chosen and rotating, all equally the Council: the one who holds the question, the voices, the scribe, and the one who speaks for whoever is affected and not present. The dilemma is never anyone's own life. A pass word or gesture hands the floor back at zero cost, mid-sentence, no explanation, and every role has a stand-in decided in rehearsal, so stepping out of a public council costs nothing. The Council opens with a sentence that says this isn't ordinary talk and closes with one that says we didn't

solve it and it's closed; you'll hear both in rehearsal. When the room's strongest disagreement is read aloud and left standing, it is in the dissenter's own words and only with their yes. The audience has been told they are witnesses, not judges.

After the Council there is a feast, and the feast is the come-down, not one more thing to get right. The base is provided, nobody watches a plate, and you do not have to eat. There is a named place to step out to that night. If your own family is not in the room, the tribe is your people, and you will not fall through this.

The flow.

Weeks 28-31 · Apr 8 - May 2 · the session break falls before this session (Apr 1-4), not inside it. The plan below describes six weeks for a four-week session. **Two weeks of it have no home on the calendar yet.** Origin cut its last session to four by moving work into the join with the session before and letting rehearsal become the dry run; what moves here is for the voices who own the material, and the Council's week in this book is not a date to give a family until it is.

Re-thread first. Weeks 1-2 build the deliberative form and work both kinds of dilemma - the one with a real third option (find it: that is skill) and the genuinely no-win one (every path costs something you cannot get back). Weeks 3-4 build and rehearse the deliberation in the tribe's safety; ask the pace question at the close of week 4. Week 5 is final rehearsal and setting the room. Week 6 is the public Council, an afternoon or evening with families and the tribe, and the feast. The year-close gets the last guided day to itself, after the feast has had its night (Part 4).

The Council is built as a real form, or teenagers in front of an audience default to what school rehearsed - debate to win:

- **Named, rotating roles:** a *convener* (holds the question, not a position), *voices* (argue the live positions in good faith), a *scribe* (writes the reasoning where the room can see it), and a *steward of the absent* (whose only job is "who is affected by this who is not in the room?").
- **A six-phase sequence:** Frame, then Divergence (surface every position and the fear under it, before anyone argues), then the mandatory Steelman, then the Cost Ledger (every path's cost and who pays, on the board), then the Turn (is the either-or real or inherited? - the Third Chair), then the Sense of the Room (where the reasoning arrived, and where it honestly did not).
- **The Steelman, mandatory and physical:** you may not argue your own position until you have voiced the best version of the one you reject, well enough that its holder says "yes,

that's it." This builds honoring dissent into the bones. Forum Theatre from Session 4 pays off here.

- **The Third Chair:** an empty chair placed between hardened sides, with four questions - what is each side protecting? Is the "or" real or inherited? What would honor both values at once? And, when there is no third option, choose from principle and carry the grief honestly.
- **A scribe and a board:** reasoning written where all can see, and read back aloud at the end of each phase so the board is heard as well as seen, becomes the object in the room, not the performers. The strongest unresolved dissent is read into the record in the dissenter's own words, with their yes, and left standing, unrefuted, as part of the harvest. A good decision carries its dissent forward visibly.
- **Mark the opening, and release:** a marked opening ("this is not ordinary talk") and a closing that completes the council without resolving the dilemma ("we did not solve it; we reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people; the council is closed"). That release lets a young person carry an unresolved hard thing without it becoming an open wound.

Let the Council deliberate something with real consequence to the community - a real policy, a real trade-off - so the reasoning matters because it is used, not graded.

Things to say. - "A council isn't a debate. A debate has a winner. A council has discernment." - "You can't argue your side until you've said the other side's best case so well its holder would say, yes, that's it." - "Sometimes there's a third door. Sometimes there isn't. Half the wisdom is finding it; the other half is knowing when there isn't one and choosing anyway, with your eyes open." - (The pass signal) "If you need the floor back, just [the agreed word or gesture]. No cost, no explanation." - (The release) "We did not solve it. We reasoned honestly, together, in front of our people. The council is closed."

The settle and the closing minute. The settle to open, a short way down in the middle of the work, the close-return at the end; pre-brief before the Council. Build a Council so a body cannot fail it: a pass signal, a word and a gesture both, that returns the floor at zero cost, because freezing is something a body does on its own, not a decision, so make it safe; ground-before-you-speak taught as the captain's own craft (feet on the floor or hands on the chair, one breath; steadying yourself is a skill, not a fix for something wrong with you); the audience briefed as witness, not judge, because a room of warm faces steadies every body in it; and the feast protected as the come-down, not one more thing to get right, because eating together in company is the body's signal that the danger is over.

What the Council leaves unresolved stays unresolved on purpose. Carrying a hard thing that has no answer yet is not waiting for the answer; it is the skill this year was for, and the feast is not where the answer arrives. The public Council is an opening in front of other people and needs its private re-crossing afterward, on the year-close day: the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words (Part 4). The capacity to close your own openings, for life, is the deepest thing this year hands a graduate.

Watch-fors. Second adult required on the deep days of the real deliberation and the public Council - public moral deliberation is being seen twice over: thinking in public, and being wrong in public. The dilemma is always external, never a learner's own life, because a public Council on your own life is a trial, and the promises say no one's life goes on a board for a room to reason about. No forced self-disclosure. A learner may pass, pause, or come back at zero cost. Name and hold the learner with no family in the room: the tribe is your people, and a chosen witness is honored equally, never as consolation.

What you'll need. A real community dilemma with actual stakes (at least one with a possible third option, at least one genuinely no-win); the roles and the six-phase form, with a stand-in for every role decided in rehearsal; a scribe's board, read back at each phase; the Third Chair; a second adult for the deep days; the pass signal, a word and a gesture both, and the exit ramp confirmed and named for the Council room; the audience told they are witnesses, not judges; the feast planned as the come-down with the full inclusion floor (base provided, presence not consumption, allergen-safe, no cover charge); the referral pathway live.

Part 4 - Closing the year and the Launch

The Council harvest

The public Council is the year's harvest and the arc's. It is the showing of reasoning, never a verdict. Close it with the release that completes it without resolving the dilemma, and protect the feast as the come-down.

The year-close

On the last guided day, after the feast has had its own night, three acts, for every learner, staying or leaving. First, a co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide, the design named not hidden - "here is how The Helm was built, and why; tell me what to change." The learner's call on their own year, never a feedback form, and declinable like every other quest. Alongside it, put the whole short record of them on the table, unasked: attendance, pace, credit plan, any safety note. Second, the Captain's Log ownership handoff, said aloud once: the Log is theirs; it goes where they say - home, or back to the one place here only they open for next year - and no copy is kept. That is the same whatever form the Log took: if any of it lives on a studio device or in a scribe's hand, it goes to the learner and nothing stays behind. For a leaving learner, this is also the day the Log goes out the door for good. Third, the closing minute at the whole year's scale, in its fixed words. It is a naming, not a new ceremony; the practice they have run all year, put in their own hand at the year's scale, and the private re-crossing the public Council needs:

> SAY
>
> "Before what comes next, take your closing minute at the whole year's scale. What did you meet this year? What do you carry back? What's different in you now - even a little? 'I don't know yet' is a real answer."

For a learner staying on, this is their close between years, and then a real fallow stretch before the next year opens; the fallow day stays empty, and nothing is seated on it. For a leaving learner, it comes before the Launch, so that they cross the threshold already home in themselves.

The Launch rite

For a leaving learner, and first of all for the founding tribe, the first ever to complete the full cycle, the Launch is a true rite of passage, built with the three movements every real threshold-crossing has. It is not a graduation that happens *to* you; it is a threshold you *cross through*. A person opens the rite, never the app, because a rite opened by a schedule happens to you; one opened by a person who knows you can be crossed through. The learner has read the whole of it in Part 1 and here before the day; nothing in it is sprung. The Launch is a crossing, not a close: the closing minute was already run on the year-close day, and the grief in the first movement is neither de-roled nor closed with it.

Leaving - the un-belonging. The part everyone skips because it hurts, and skipping it is why so many graduations feel hollow. First, go back through the Growth Record together, in whatever form the learner takes it in, and arrive at where you have been; the Journey view is private, so reading it is the learner's invitation, alone or with the guide for company. Then the grief and the thanks. This is the real work of this part. The ending is named straight out - "this was your home; you are being released from it" - and it is allowed to be sad, held, and not rushed, with a real exit available. Do not use the de-roling move for this grief. De-roling steps you out of a role that was never you. Leaving home is stepping out of a self that truly was you. Never teach a young person to de-role their own real sorrow. For some, leaving here means leaving the steadiest place they have had, for somewhere not yet steady. That is allowed to be more than excitement; the guide holds it as a coach and routes what is bigger.

In between - the threshold, held. No longer a learner, not yet launched. Here the learner is given the Star Chart, the map of where they have been. It is given as a thing to carry over the threshold, not as a slide at a graduation, because this is the exact moment they must steer by it alone. There is a silence around it, and no one fills it; that silence is on purpose. Then the learner makes their next-step plan: their own plan for themselves, in their own hand or voice, with the guide as witness. It is not the studio's plan for them.

Coming in on the far side - the crossing, seen by your people, and a change in how they see you. This is the actual step into adulthood, witnessed by their people. The handoff comes first. The learner makes their Portrait export, piece by piece, and decides who sees it, and takes it.

This part cannot be a ceremony over a placeholder, so the real export, in the learner's own hands, must exist before any real learner walks this rite. Then the learner decides what to do with the Mantle: keep it (this is who I am now) or leave it (it belonged to this place). Either choice is true; the choosing is the rite. Then they leave a gift for the room. Then the crossing itself: a doorway, or a line on the floor, that the learner crosses in whatever way they move, while their people watch, into a circle of adults who receive them as an adult and speak to them differently on the far side. The circle is made before the day, with the learner. It can hold their family, a mentor, the one adult outside the room, the adults of the tribe's families, the second adult who sat with us on the heavy days. If their own family is not in it, it is still a full circle, and if they would rather cross with one person than a crowd, it is the same crossing. A rite that does not change how your community sees you is a going-away party. This one changes it. A crossing not made costs nothing; the learner is still launched.

The empty exit. Then the Launch itself: the door closes and stays unlocked from the learner's side. No come-back nudge, ever, because the only proof the door was real is that it stays open from their side only; one nudge turns a launch into a subscription. No campaign to bring them back, no pull on former learners, nothing sold at the door. A launched learner who never returns is a success, not a loss. This is not negotiable under any future pressure.

Leaving a gift for the room

The rite is built around what the learner *takes*, but a threshold is also a community losing a member. So the launched learner leaves one small thing behind that is wholly theirs to give - a word to the next captain, a mark, their Vineyard-thing if they choose. The tribe marks the departure *as a tribe*, not the guide performing it at them - the threshold felt from both sides of the door. For the founding tribe, what they leave becomes the room's first inheritance, so each leaving adds to a line the next group inherits.

The learner with no family in the room is the one this day can let fall. "Crossing witnessed by your people" is the day it falls hardest. Name the tribe as *your people*, in advance and explicitly - the same inclusion floor the whole program holds, applied to the most tender day of all their years here.

What the learner leaves holding: the Growth Record (the backward face - their trail), the next-step plan (the forward face - their plan), and the Captain's Log (their private voice, always theirs, never read for assessment). And the practice they carry inside them - the settle, and the three fixed lines they can run on themselves at a kitchen table at 2 a.m. for the rest of their life.

The arc completes.

“We evoke - we never extract.” The honesty is the gift; the container is the care. Held, this year can change a person. That is a hope, not a promise.

NOTES